

Speaking from Above

A Social Meaning Game for Relational Slurs

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What is a slur?

The standard view

- Slurs are **group pejoratives**: they apply to individuals in virtue of membership into a group.
- Slurs target **objectively identifiable** groups.
- Many adopt the **Identity Thesis** (Diaz-Legaspe, 2020): a slur has an actual or possible neutral counterpart with the same truth-conditional contribution.
- Non-derogatory uses are seen **as peripheral**. Theories first try to fix the derogatory core, and then explain odd cases (e.g., in-group uses) as derivative.

What is a slur?

- In summary:
 1. Slurs as tools of group hatred
 2. Stable target groups
 3. Actual or possible neutral counterparts
 4. Non-derogatory uses are peripheral
- Standard examples:
 - *K*** / Jew*
 - *F*** / gay*
 - *S*** / Hispanic*
 - Etc.

Claims

1. The standard model overfits WEIRD cases of slurring.
 - It treats slurs as group labels with stable targets and possible neutral counterparts.
2. Latin American cases expose a different pattern.
 - *Cholo*, *naco*, and *negro* often track rank or trajectory, not fixed group membership.
3. These are relational slurs.
 - Their core function is to position a target below a speaker on a contextually salient hierarchy.
4. Their use is strategic and audience-sensitive.
 - A social meaning game explains uses of these slurs.

Plan

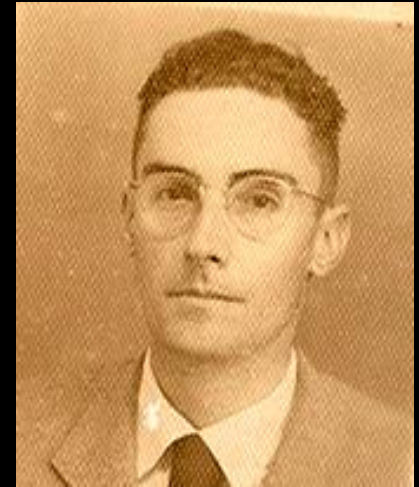
- I. Background: introducing Relational Slurs
- II. Towards a social meaning game of RS
- III. An example: A stylized cocktail party
- IV. Some qualitative predictions

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Why the Standard Model is Problematic

- Assumptions 2, 3, and 4 come from a social organization closer to the US/UK reality.
- Oracy Nogueira's (1955) distinction:



Prejudice of origin

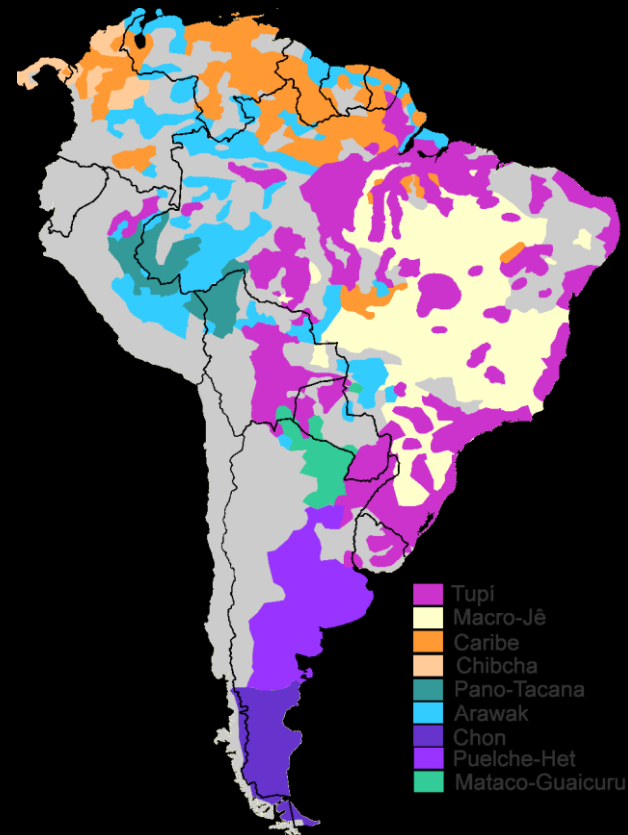
In the U.S., prejudice is historically closer to descent, ancestry, group membership. This supports segregation.

Prejudice of mark

In Brazil, prejudice operates by visible traits such as color, hair, and social presentation. This supports appearance-based hierarchies.

Racist talk in Latin America as a test case

- **Mexico:** education/wealth increases classification as “mestizo” or white.
- **Peru:** Race is often displaced into “cultural” talk (how civilized one is).
- **Argentina:** promoted myth that Black people disappeared. “Blackness” is treated as peripheral, foreign, and context-dependent.



Some language families in South America

Slurring in Latin America

- **In Mexico**, *naco* targets people seen as vulgar, “low” in taste, and lower-class; it is racialized, but not tied to one stable ethnicity (see also *indio*, *gato*, *prieto*)
- **In Peru**, *cholo* is linked to brown-skinned Indigenous and mestizo people, but its primary force comes from lowering someone socially (see also *serrano*, *provinciano*, *motoso*).
- **In Argentina**, *negro* racializes any type of distance from whiteness, social inferiority, coarseness, or marginality (see also *villero*, *cabeza negra*, *grasa*)

The pattern is similar: these terms track **relative position in a social axis**, not membership in a stable group.



Not only ethnic slurs

Latin American **gendered slurs** mainly work like graded positioning terms.

- They mainly police where someone falls on scales of masculinity/femininity, active/passive roles, respectability, and decorum.
- In Mexico:
 - *Mayate*: denotes broad sexual/racial outsidership.
 - *Maricón*: linked to gender nonconformity
 - *Joto/puto*: targets passive sexual role

Introducing a new category:

Relational Slurs

- Terms like *cholo*, *naco*, or *mayate* are slurs whose use presupposes:
 - A contex-dependent **social axis**
 - A **direction** (from above to below)
- Their interpretation depends on speaker–target relation, not fixed group reference.
- They mainly do **social positioning work**:
 - Saying “Juan is a X” marks Juan as below the speaker with respect to a local scale of, for instance, whiteness, class, education, masculinity, respectability, etc.

Introducing a new category:

Relational Slurs

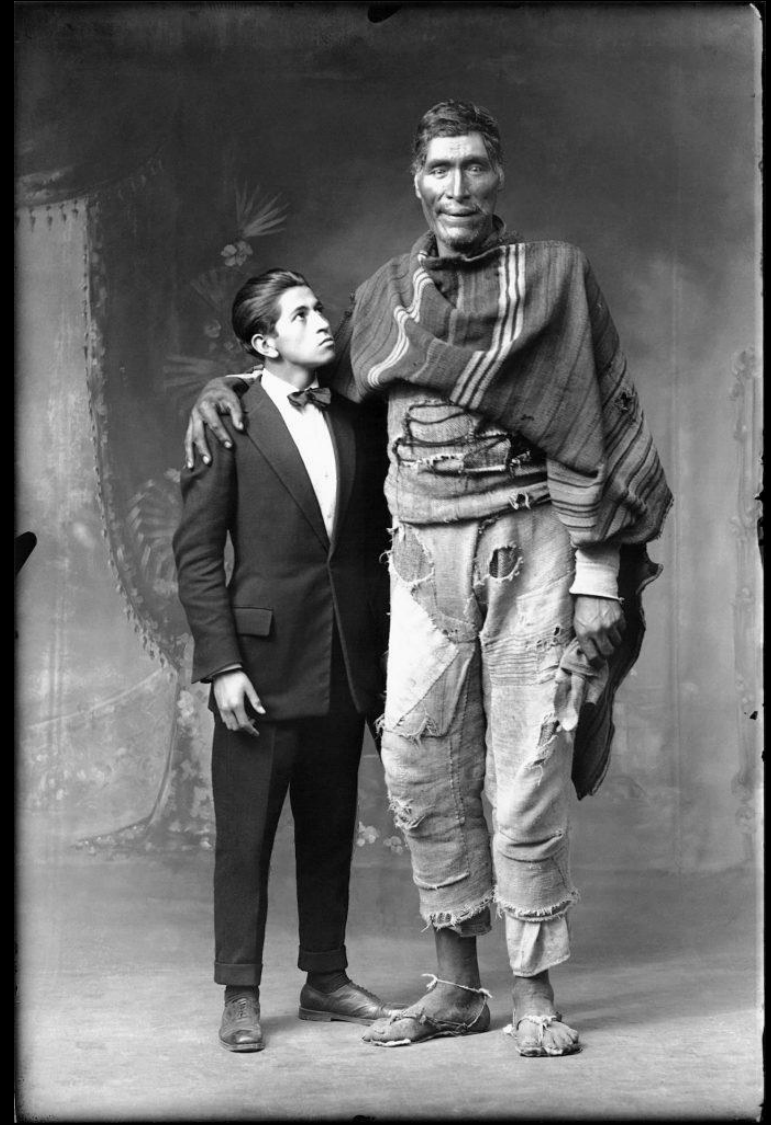
Note:

- Diachronically, relational slurs such as *cholo*, *naco*, *negro*, or *mayate* may have originally denoted estable social groups.
- But the point is **synchronic**: now, in their **primary uses**, they serve as “stairway” labels.

A case study

Cholo in Peruvian Spanish

- *Cholo* is historically linked to:
 - Indigeneity, rural migration
 - Now, it marks people as “lower” or subordinate
 - **Cholification:** the incorporation of Andean migrants into urban life
 - *Cholo* is a **trajectory**
 - People are evaluated as more or less *cholo*
- The term *cholo* tracks this movement on a hierarchy.



Martin Chambi, *Two Giants*

Stairway subordination

(Flores Galindo, 1997; Quijano, 1980; Nugent, 1992)

- The same person can be *cholo* for one speaker, but not be *cholo* for another.
 - White elites call *cholos* the upwardly mobile mestizos;
 - these, may call *cholos* those they see as more “provincial” or “uncultured”,
 - and so on.
- Thus, relational slurs like *cholo*:
 - Serve both **to demean** and **to socially locate**.
 - Don’t refer to a **estable social group**.
 - Have no actual or potential “**neutral**” **counterpart**.

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Meaning as layered

- Relational slurs express stance **and** enact social ordering.
- We need a framework that captures both functions.
 - I posit two interacting layers for relational slurs:

Affective layer

- Valence (positive / negative)
- Dominance (power, control)

Social layer

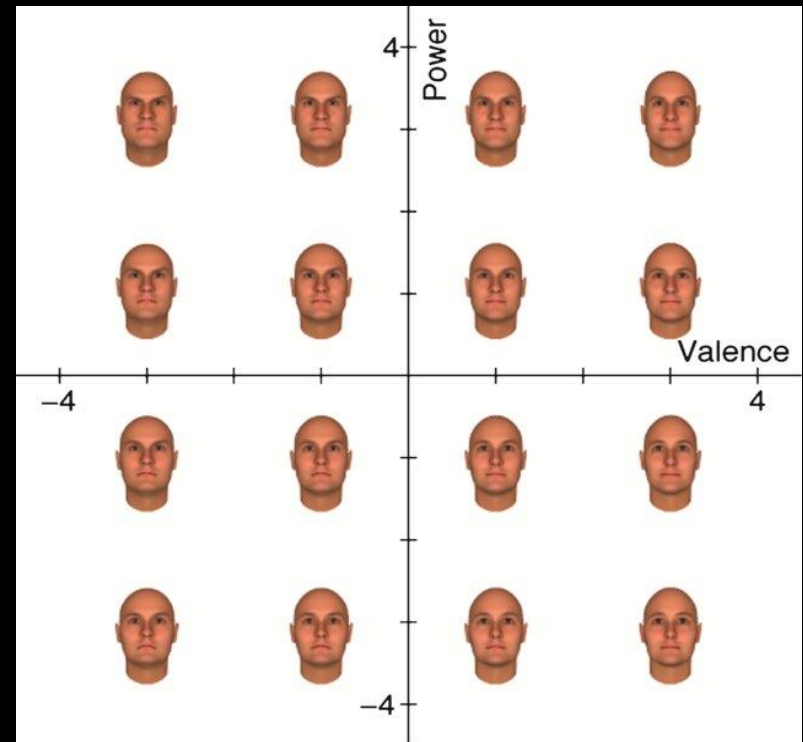
- Speaker's position
- Target's position
- Salient social axis (δ)

- Ochs (1990, 1993): forms **directly** index momentary attitudes, and **indirectly** index more stable social identities.

The Valence–Dominance Layer

Oosterhof & Todorov (2008)

- Two dimensions:
 - Valence (V) → are intentions helpful or harmful?
 - Dominance (D) → can the agent impose those intentions?
- Let the set of all possible stances be
$$A = \{\alpha = \langle V, D \rangle : V, D \in \mathbb{R}\}$$



Todorov et al. (2011)

The social layer

- It is a space of orderings interpreted through, but not reducible to, stance.
- Assume that, in a given community, there is at least:
 - one contextually salient axis δ with an ordering $>_{\delta}$ over positions
 - For example, racialized class, urban–rural, “respectability”
- Along a Peruvian racialized class axis, we may have:
 1. “White upper-class Limeños from coastal districts”,
 2. “Upwardly mobile mestizos from mixed districts”,
 3. “Racialized Andean migrants”,
 4. and so on.

Social admissibility set

- Let Σ be the set of possible social configurations σ
 - Each configuration σ specifies
 - I. The contextually salient axis δ
 - II. A position function pos_δ , assigning speaker (S) and target (T) locations on that axis
 - The **social admissibility set** for the slurring use of *cholo* is
 - $\text{Soc}(\text{cholo}) = \{\sigma \in \Sigma: \text{pos}_\delta(S) >_\delta \text{pos}_\delta(T) \text{ and } T \text{ is construed as a racialized "other" in } \sigma\}$.
- This captures the idea that *cholo* is only felicitous **from above**.

Unifying the layers

- The full **indexical field** I of *cholo* is then:
 - a set of pairs $I(\text{cholo}) \subseteq \Sigma \times A$
 - with $\langle \sigma, \alpha \rangle \in I(\text{cholo})$ only if:
 - $\sigma \in \text{Soc}(\text{cholo})$ and
 - $\alpha = \langle V, D \rangle$ lies in a region of A **with high D**
- Thus:
 - the **social layer** fixes who is above whom and who can be called *cholo* at all;
 - the **stance layer** fixes how that relational move is affectively inflected (from hostile to paternalistic).

Offensiveness as dominance

- Hypothesis: uses of a relational slur X are offensive when
 - i. they are interpreted against a social configuration $\sigma \in \text{Soc}(X)$ in which $\text{pos}_\delta(S) >_\delta \text{pos}_\delta(T)$; **and**
 - ii. they occupy a sufficiently high- D region of the stance space A .

Some predictions:

- Positively valenced uses of slurs (e.g., *Cholos are hard workers*) are still offensive
- When the speaker is “below” the target in δ , uses of L will fail to be (morally) offensive.

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- Elite spaces are key sites where whitening projects are staged.

MÁS VIDA SOCIAL



The situation

- A mestizo speaker S is talking to a group G of elite listeners $L_1, \dots, L_n$ about a more racialized target T .
- By hypothesis, σ is in Soc(cholo):
 $\text{pos}_\delta(L_i) >_\delta \text{pos}_\delta(S) >_\delta \text{pos}_\delta(T)$ for all i .
- The issue is whether using *cholo* is a “good move” for S .

Types and personae

- Following Burnett (2023), I take the socially relevant “state” to be a persona or social identity. Let

$$P = \{p_E, p_P, p_A\}$$

Where:

- p_E : old guard elite persona (usually high on δ);
- p_P : progressive elite persona (usually high on δ).
- p_A : aspirational mestizo persona (usually mid on δ).

Types and personae

- I identify the speaker's type t with one of these personae;
 - listeners do not know t ,
 - but have priors over P .
- I assume S is of type p_A : someone trying to align with elites by “punching down.”

Messages

- The message set is minimal:
 - $M = \{m_0, m_1\}$, with:
 - m_0 : a description of T (e.g., *el chico de Cuzco*);
 - m_1 : the relational slur *cholo*.
- The key difference lies in their indexical fields:
 - $I(m_0)$ allows low D stances and does not impose a relational condition.
 - $I(m_1)$ is restricted to high D stance profiles and to Soc(cholo).

Listener beliefs and inference

- Each listener $L \in G$ has
 - i. a prior $P_L(p)$ over speaker personae p ,
 - ii. a production model $P_L(m \mid p)$: how likely they take a speaker with persona p to choose each message.
- Upon hearing m , L updates to a posterior via Bayes' rule:

$$P_L(p \mid m) \propto P_L(p) P_L(m \mid p).$$

Listener beliefs and inference

- I assume heterogeneous listeners (Henderson & McCready, 2018).
Some elites are “vigilant” and treat *cholo* as diagnostic of a racist persona; others treat it as normal banter.
- For a vigilant L^* , we may have likelihoods such that
$$P_{L^*}(m_1 \mid p_E) > P_{L^*}(m_1 \mid p_A) \gg P_{L^*}(m_1 \mid p_P),$$
and posteriors such that
$$P_{L^*}(p_A \mid m_1) \gg P_{L^*}(p_E \mid m_1) \gg P_{L^*}(p_P \mid m_1)$$
- Note: vigilant $\neq$ progressive.

Utilities and group evaluation

- Let $v_L(p)$ be the payoff for the speaker of being taken, by L , to have persona p . For an aspirational type, we expect:
 - $v_L(p_E)$ and $v_L(p_A)$ tends to be high when L is an old-guard elite,
 - and $v_L(p_P)$ to be higher when L is a progressive elite member.

- The expected social utility of m for S (with respect to L) is

$$U_S^{\text{soc}}(m, L) = \sum_{p \in P} P_L(p \mid m) v_L(p).$$

- But, plausibly, S cares about how they are valued in the room:

$$U_S^{\text{soc}}(m, G) = \sum_{L \in G} U_S^{\text{soc}}(m, L).$$

Costs of high- D slur use

- I introduce a cost function $C(m, \sigma)$ with:
 - i. $C(m_0, \sigma) = 0$
 - ii. $C(m_1, \sigma) = K(\sigma) \geq 0$
- $K(\sigma)$ increases with the “normative sensitivity” of the context.

- The total utility to S of sending m in σ is then:
$$U_S(m, G, \sigma) = U_S^{\text{SOC}}(m, G) - C(m, \sigma).$$

- ΔU_S is the net gain from using *cholo*:
$$\Delta U_S = U_S(m_1, G, \sigma) - U_S(m_0, G, \sigma).$$

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Old-guard elite cocktail

- In this context, we expect
 - i. for the speaker, being taken by L as either p_E or p_A is socially valuable, or at least not costly;
 - ii. relatively weakly diagnostic posteriors: for complacent old-guard listeners m_1 does not sharply distinguish p_E from p_A
 - iii. a small $K(\sigma)$: the risk of explicit sanction is low.
- For such audiences, ΔU_S can be > 0 : for an aspirational speaker p_A , *cholo* may slightly increase their chances of being seen as “one of us” relative to a neutral term.
- **Prediction:** in elite settings *cholo* is an alignment strategy for upwardly mobile mestizos.

Mixed or progressive elite contexts

- In a cocktail with a larger proportion of progressive elites, we have more listeners L' such that:
 - i. $v_{L'}(p_E) \ll 0$ and $v_{L'}(p_A) \ll 0$: they disvalue racist personae; and
 - ii. $P_{L'}(p_E \mid m_1)$ and/or $P_{L'}(p_A \mid m_1)$ are high: they treat *cholo* as a reliable cue of racism or aspirational racism.
- As the proportion of vigilant L' grows and $K(\sigma)$ increases, ΔU_S becomes negative for increasingly many types, including p_A .
- **Prediction:** even speakers with racist private attitudes may refrain from overt *cholo* uses, because the expected reputational costs outweigh any alignment gains.

Aspirational misfires

- The model also makes room for cases of miscalculation.
 - A. A non-strategic S_0 -type speaker may simply use *cholo* “because that’s how we talk”, treating $P_L(p \mid m_1) \approx P_L(p)$ and $K(\sigma)$ as negligible.
 - B. A more strategic S_1 -type speaker may know there are progressive elites present but misjudge their proportion or vigilance.
- In both cases, the speaker behaves as if $\Delta U_S > 0$ while we in fact have $\Delta U_S < 0$.
- **Prediction:** the speaker is reclassified by elites as racist or as a “social climber” rather than as a safe insider.

Final take

- There is an often neglected class of expressions, **relational slurs**, whose behavior is poorly captured by standard views.
- These slurs don't just express contempt, but position speakers and targets within a lived hierarchy.



Final take

- More empirical work is needed:
 - Annotated corpus of everyday slurring and media texts.
 - Matched-guise tasks that manipulate speaker background and audience composition.
- In sum, we need a more sociologically informed analysis of slurs, less tied to WEIRD social regimes.



Many thanks!

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